

MARCHING TO HER OWN TUNE
Mamata Banerjee at the TMC's solidarity rally for secularism, peace and religious harmony in Kolkata, Jan. 22

AP

MAMATA SAYS SHE WAITED 210 DAYS SINCE I.N.D.I.A. FIRST MET IN JUNE 2023 FOR THE CONGRESS TO TAKE A DECISION ON SEAT-SHARING

however, was willing to offer only the two seats—Berhampore and Maldaha Dakshin—that the Congress had won in 2019 and was ready to give a third seat if the Congress agreed to share seats in Assam and Meghalaya. The Congress, however, would not settle for anything less than six seats in West Bengal and was against any tie-up in the northeastern states. Nor was the party's central leadership able to rein in its Bengal stalwart Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury, who made it a habit of launching scathing salvos on Mamata and other TMC leaders.

The Congress record in seats where it is in direct contest with the BJP has not been very inspiring either, going by the results of the 2019 general election. This when, as psephologist Pradeep Gupta points out, the possibility of a non-BJP government hinges significantly on how the Congress performs in these direct contests. Of the 423 seats the Congress contested in 2019 (of which it won only 52), the party faced the BJP directly in 186 seats (of which it won only 16). This time, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge has asked the party to concentrate on 255 seats where it fancies its chances of winning. Of these, 128 seats are in seven states—Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Karnataka. In 2019, the Congress managed to win a paltry four of these. Another 88 seats are in Assam, other states in the Northeast, Odisha, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, where the Congress, and not I.N.D.I.A., will face either the BJP or a regional party. The Congress tally here was 17 in 2019.

If there is any hope for the Opposition camp, it lies South of the Vindhyas. The BJP's imprint is marginal in five of the six southern states. Non-BJP parties, therefore, expect to net well over half of the 130 seats. But they include not just the likes of the DMK and the Left in Tamil Nadu/ Kerala, but also non-I.N.D.I.A. parties such as the YSR Congress, Telugu Desam Party (TDP) and the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS). So it falls upon the Congress to do some heavy lifting—say, by denying the BJP a repeat of 2019 when it won 25 of Karnataka's 28 seats in Karnataka. Buoyed by its success in the Karnataka and Telangana assembly polls, the Congress is expecting to significantly improve its 2019 tally of four out of the total of 45 seats in